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MAX REIGNS SUPREME IN SUZUKA

Back to the norm: It was Max's third win of the season in four races after retiring due to a technical failure in Australia a fortnight ago. GETTYIMAGES



The defending champion dominated the Japanese GP as Red Bull **clinched another 1-2 finish** while Mercedes continued to struggle.

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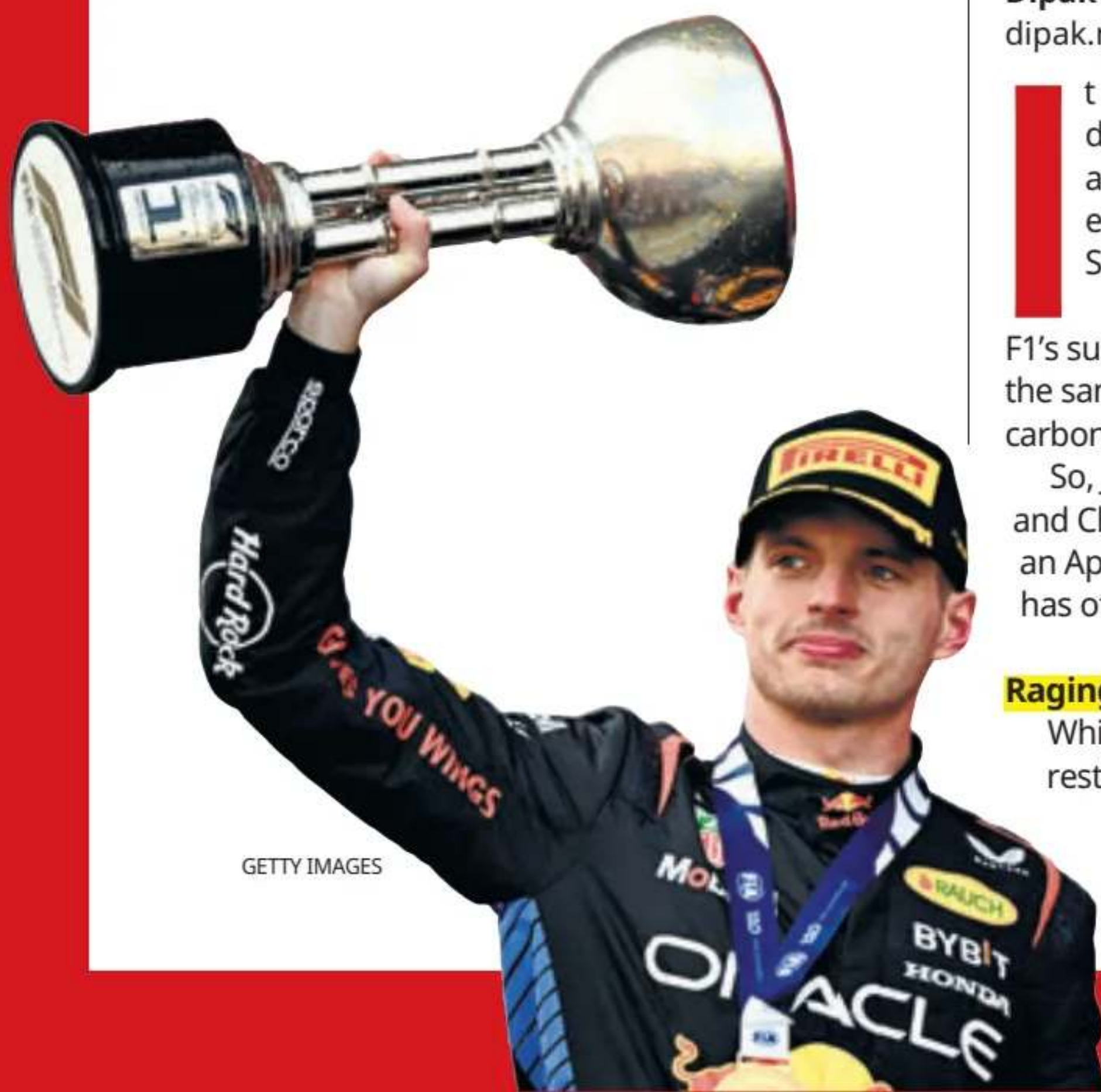
It is springtime, and the cherry blossoms were in full display in Suzuka when Formula One made its annual stop there for the Japanese Grand Prix, albeit earlier in the season rather than its traditional late September or early October slot.

The Japanese GP was mainly moved because of F1's sustainability push. The sport is trying to club races in the same geography together to reduce logistics costs and carbon footprint by moving things across the world.

So, Japan was sandwiched between races in Australia and China. Also, October is typhoon season in Japan, and an April date ensures minimal risk of heavy rains, which has often affected race weekends.

Raging bulls

While the scheduling changed, Max Verstappen restored things to normalcy on track, doing what he



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